

There are many popular freeware and shareware Registry cleaners. Each has its own fan following. While the jury is still out on how to effectively clean the Registry, we advise caution as the wiser course. Better to have a slightly slower system than break something, which “ain’t broke” in the first place!

One approach is to not rely entirely on a single cleaner, and to use two or three cleaners that look at the Registry from different perspectives.

When choosing a Registry cleaner, there are two key factors to consider. One, the cleaner shouldn’t be overly aggressive, as this can potentially cause more problems than solve them. Second, the cleaning should work consistently: that is, after cleaning once, when running the cleaner a second time, it shouldn’t come up with the same (or a similar) number of errors.

Many cleaners, in a bid to show that they are superior to other cleaners, tend to include irrelevant results in their cleaning scan. This invariably gets repeated on subsequent scans, giving the impression that these cleaners are doing something special, while the fact is they are just picking up irrelevant results.

Ideally, you should start the computer, run the cleaner immediately (before opening any other applications), then reboot and do a second scan, and if warranted reboot again for a third scan. By the third scan, only low-severity persistent errors should be reported by the cleaner. These errors are, strictly speaking, not errors, but “ghost” entries left over from the normal working of the Registry—and are usually safe to ignore.

The cleaners we review here fulfil both the above conditions. One, they are not too aggressive in their scans; and two, once the cleaner has run through its scan once, a second or third scan will only pick up a minuscule number of entries that did not get reported during the first scan.